concept of siting brigade defences at heights of 4,000 metres [13,400 feet] and over as impracticable.'

By the end of October, winter had well and truly set in, with frequent white-outs and snowfall at Se-la Top and the surrounding heights. This plan, also accepted by Harbaksh Singh, was based on the five infantry battalions allotted to 62 Brigade eventually defending a compact area at 13,400 feet with additional defensive positions on the two shoulders at around 16,000 feet. HQ 4 Division was to be located at Senge Dzong, just below the southern face of Se-la, with 65 Brigade's two battalions (4 Rajput and 19 MLI) defending the flanks.

Anant Pathania, ever since he took over 4 Division, seemed most reluctant to base himself at Senge, ostensibly on account of high altitude headaches. Kaul's reinstatement gave Pathania the opportunity to request permission to pull back and set up his Division HQ at Dirang Dzong, which at 6,000 feet was appreciably lower in altitude. Without giving it too much thought, Kaul gave Pathania permission. The GOC correspondingly changed the assigned task of 65 Brigade, deploying it with an eye towards protecting his own HQ while considerably reducing the proposed defences on the flank. The fact that Division HQ had been pulled back to Dirang was not known to either Eastern Command or Army HQ, both of which had once again faded into the backdrop with the re-emergence of Kaul.

Apart from the units that had fallen back from Tawang and were now part of 62 Brigade, the new units coming in from the plains were short of blankets, digging tools and critical signals equipment. 4 Sikh LI had been airlifted from Dagshai via Ambala, Agra and Tezpur, and had reached Se-la on October 24; bewildered and tired, they watched the exodus of Tawang's panic-stricken population. These troops, without any preamble or acclimatization, had been deployed ahead of Se-la to guard the approach to Nuranang and the Kya-la-Lunguthang track. Two of their companies were deployed in the Two Lakes area while a third company was in depth behind 4 Garhwal at Nuranang. 2 Sikh LI had moved from Hyderabad without its commanding officer and had reached Se-la Top between 26 and 28 October. Of the battalions that had fallen back from Tawang, 4 Garhwal Rifles were dug in at Nuranang, 1 Sikh was holding Se-la Top and 13 Dogra was responsible for the defence of Senge DZ while also providing depth to the troops deployed at Se-la.